

CSCI 232

232 Algorithms & Data Structures

LECTURE: 8

J. L. Pach

OUTLINE

- Stack memory — recap
- Heap memory — `malloc` and `free`
- Traversal — walking a linked list
- `detachFirst` — step by step
- `detachValue` — edge cases

STACK VS HEAP

Recap

STACK MEMORY — WHAT YOU ALREADY KNOW

```c
void someFunction(void)
{
    Node a;              // born here
    initNode(&a, 10);
    // ...
}                        // dies here — automatically
```



- Allocated automatically when a function is called.
- Freed automatically when the function returns.
- You cannot control the lifetime — the compiler does.
- Safe, fast, but limited in scope.

> A stack node returned by address is a **dangling pointer**.
> The memory is gone — you are pointing at nothing valid.

THE PROBLEM STACK CANNOT SOLVE

```c
Node* buildList(void)
{
    Node a;
    initNode(&a, 10);
    return &a;        // WRONG — a dies when function returns
}
int main(void)
{
    Node *headPtr = buildList();
    // headPtr points to dead memory
    // undefined behavior
}
```



We need nodes that **outlive the function that created them**.

We need nodes that **exist as long as we decide**.

That is what the heap is for.

HEAP MEMORY

malloc & free

MALLOC — MEMORY ALLOCATION 1/2

```
#include <stdlib.h>

Node *nodePtr = malloc(sizeof(Node));  // in C++:  (Node*) malloc(sizeof(Node));
```



- `malloc` asks the operating system for a block of memory.
- Returns a pointer to the first byte of that block.
- Returns `NULL` if allocation fails — always check.
- The memory exists until YOU call `free()`.
- No automatic cleanup — you are responsible.

MALLOC — MEMORY ALLOCATION 2/2

```c
Node *nodePtr = malloc(sizeof(Node));
if (nodePtr == NULL)
{
    fprintf(stderr, "Error: malloc failed.\n");
    return NULL;
}
```



> Never assume `malloc` succeeded. Always guard.

FREE — RELEASING MEMORY 1/2

```c
free(nodePtr);
nodePtr = NULL;   // critical — prevents dangling pointer
```



- `free` returns the memory block to the operating system.
- After `free` — the pointer still holds the old address.
- That address is no longer valid — **dangling pointer**.
- Always set the pointer to `NULL` after `free`.
- `free(NULL)` is safe — it does nothing.

FREE — RELEASING MEMORY 2/2

```c
// WRONG — double free
free(nodePtr);
free(nodePtr);    // undefined behavior — program may crash
```



```c
// SAFE — nullify after free
free(nodePtr);
nodePtr = NULL;
free(nodePtr);    // free(NULL) — safe, does nothing
```



STACK VS HEAP — SIDE BY SIDE 1/2

```c
// STACK
Node a;
initNode(&a, 10);
// no free needed — dies automatically
```



```c
// HEAP
Node *nodePtr = malloc(sizeof(Node));
initNode(nodePtr, 10);
// must free manually
free(nodePtr);
nodePtr = NULL;
```



STACK VS HEAP — SIDE BY SIDE 2/2

	Stack	Heap
Lifetime	function scope	until `free()`
Allocation	automatic	`malloc()`
Cleanup	automatic	`free()` — your job
Dangling pointer risk	no	yes

createNode — Stack Replaced by Heap

```c
Node a; // stack — works only inside this scope
initNode(&a, 10);
```

```c
Node* createNode(int value) // heap — lives as long as you need
{
    Node *newNodePtr = malloc(sizeof(Node));
    if (newNodePtr == NULL)
    {
        fprintf(stderr, "Error: malloc failed.\n");
        return NULL;
    }
    initNode(newNodePtr, value);
    return newNodePtr;    // safe — heap memory outlives function
}
```

> `createNode` returns a pointer to **heap memory**. The caller is responsible for calling `free` eventually.

destroyNode — free + nullify

```c
void destroyNode(Node **nodePtrPtr)
{
    if (nodePtrPtr == NULL || *nodePtrPtr == NULL)
        return;
    free(*nodePtrPtr);          // release the memory
    *nodePtrPtr = NULL;         // prevent dangling pointer
}
```

Why `Node **nodePtrPtr` and not `Node *nodePtr`?

```c
// if we only had Node *nodePtr:
void destroyNode_BROKEN(Node *nodePtr)
{
    free(nodePtr);
    nodePtr = NULL;    // changes LOCAL copy only
}                      // caller's pointer still dangles
// with Node **nodePtrPtr:
destroyNode(&nodePtr); // caller's pointer becomes NULL ✓
```

TRAVERSAL

Walking a Linked List

The Core Pattern

```c
Node *currentPtr = headPtr;

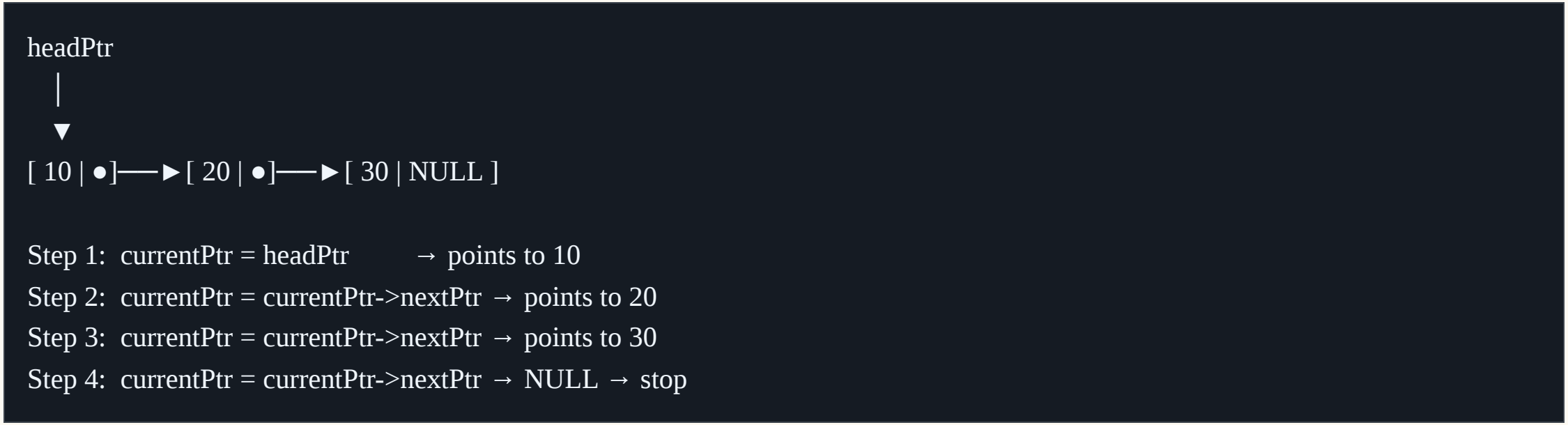
while (currentPtr != NULL)
{
   // do something with currentPtr->value
   currentPtr = currentPtr->nextPtr;
}
```



- Start at `headPtr` — never modify it directly during traversal.
- Use a **local cursor** `currentPtr` — a copy of the pointer.
- At each step: process the node, then move to `nextPtr`.
- Stop when `currentPtr` reaches `NULL` — end of list.

> `headPtr` after traversal is **unchanged**.
> `currentPtr` was a local copy — it moved, not `headPtr`.

TRAVERSAL — MEMORY PICTURE



PRINTLIST — TRAVERSAL IN PRACTICE

```c
int printList(Node *headPtr)
{
    if (headPtr == NULL)
    {
        printf("List is empty.\n");
        return -1;
    }

    Node *currentPtr = headPtr;

    while (currentPtr != NULL)
    {
        printf("%d\n", currentPtr->value);
        currentPtr = currentPtr->nextPtr;
    }
    return 0;
}
```



listLength — Counting with Traversal

```c
int listLength(Node *headPtr)
{
   int   count      = 0;
   Node *currentPtr = headPtr;

   while (currentPtr != NULL)
   {
      count++;
      currentPtr = currentPtr->nextPtr;
   }
   return count;
}
```



> Same pattern — different action at each node.
>
> Traversal is always the same loop.
>
> Only what you do **inside** the loop changes.

_findLast — Walk to the End

```c
static Node* _findLast(Node *headPtr)
{
    if (headPtr == NULL)
        return NULL;

    Node *currentPtr = headPtr;

    while (currentPtr->nextPtr != NULL)
        currentPtr = currentPtr->nextPtr;

    return currentPtr;
}
```



Note the condition — `currentPtr->nextPtr != NULL`.

We stop **at** the last node, not **after** it.

We need to return a pointer to it — so we must stop before going past it.

STEP BY STEP

detachFirst

DETACHFIRST — WHAT IT DOES

```
BEFORE:
   headPtr ──► [ 10 | ●]──►[ 20 | ●]──►[ 30 | NULL ]

AFTER detachFirst(&headPtr):
   headPtr ──► [ 20 | ●]──►[ 30 | NULL ]

   returned ──► [ 10 | NULL ]   ← nextPtr cleared
```

The node is **removed from the list** but NOT freed.

The caller decides what to do with it:

- Stack node → do nothing
- Heap node → call `destroyNode`

detachFirst — Implementation

```
Node* detachFirst(Node **headPtrPtr)
{
    if (headPtrPtr == NULL || *headPtrPtr == NULL)
        return NULL;

    Node *detachedPtr = *headPtrPtr;        // save the node
    *headPtrPtr       = (*headPtrPtr)->nextPtr; // advance head
    detachedPtr->nextPtr = NULL;            // clear the link

    return detachedPtr;
}
```



Three steps — always in this order:

1. Save pointer to the node we are removing.
2. Move headPtr forward to the next node.
3. Clear nextPtr of the detached node — it is now isolated.

DETACHFIRST — STEP BY STEP IN MEMORY

```
Step 1 — save:
    detachedPtr ──► [ 10 | ●]──►[ 20 | ... ]
    headPtr     ──► [ 10 | ●]──►[ 20 | ... ]

Step 2 — advance head:
    detachedPtr ──► [ 10 | ●]──►[ 20 | ... ]
    headPtr     ──►             [ 20 | ... ]

Step 3 — clear link:
    detachedPtr ──► [ 10 | NULL ]
    headPtr     ──► [ 20 | ●]──►[ 30 | NULL ]
```

> After step 3 — the detached node is completely isolated.
> The list starts at 20. The caller has 10.

deleteFirst — detach + destroy

```c
int deleteFirst(Node **headPtrPtr)
{
    Node *detachedPtr = detachFirst(headPtrPtr);
    if (detachedPtr == NULL)
    {
        fprintf(stderr, "Error: list is empty.\n");
        return -1;
    }
    destroyNode(&detachedPtr);
    return 0;
}
```



`deleteFirst` is just two lines of logic:

```
detach → the list no longer owns the node
destroy → we no longer own the node either
```

> This is the heap version. Stack version is just `detachFirst` — no destroy.

EDGE CASES

detachValue

detachValue — Three Cases

```
List:  [ 10 ]──►[ 20 ]──►[ 30 ]──►NULL

Case 1 — value is at the HEAD:
    detachValue(&headPtr, 10)
    → call detachFirst — already written ✓

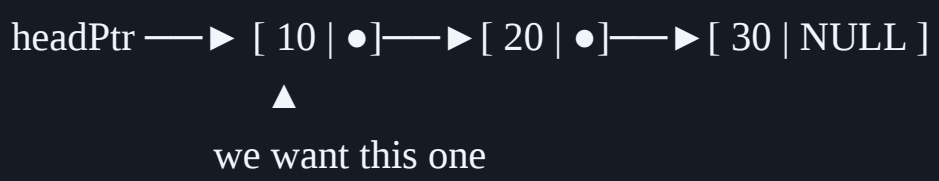
Case 2 — value is in the MIDDLE or at the END:
    detachValue(&headPtr, 20)
    detachValue(&headPtr, 30)
    → traverse to find the node BEFORE it
    → bypass it

Case 3 — value NOT FOUND:
    detachValue(&headPtr, 99)
    → return NULL
```

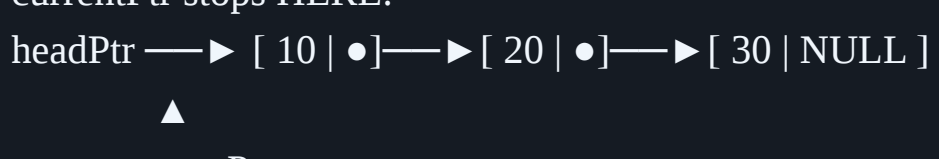
> Case 1 is special because there is no previous node.
> Always handle it first — then traverse for cases 2 and 3.

detachValue — Middle/Last Bypass

BEFORE detachValue(&headPtr, 20):



currentPtr stops HERE:



currentPtr->nextPtr == node with value 20

AFTER bypass:



DETACHVALUE — IMPLEMENTATION

```
// haha
```



detachValue — Why `currentPtr->nextPtr`

```
while (currentPtr->nextPtr != NULL)
{
   if (currentPtr->nextPtr->value == value)
```



We look **one node ahead** — not at `currentPtr` itself.

Why? Because to remove a node we need to modify the **previous** node's `nextPtr`. If we stop at the node we want to remove — it is too late, we have lost access to its predecessor.

```
currentPtr        currentPtr->nextPtr
    |                   |
    ▼                   ▼
[ 10 | ●]──────────────►[ 20 | ●]──►[ 30 | NULL ]
```

We check value at currentPtr->nextPtr.
If it matches — we can do:
   currentPtr->nextPtr = currentPtr->nextPtr->nextPtr

SUMMARY

Function	Memory	What it does
`createNode`	heap	`malloc` + `initNode`
`destroyNode`	heap	`free` + `NULL`
`detachFirst`	stack + heap	removes head, no free
`detachValue`	stack + heap	finds and removes, no free
`deleteFirst`	heap	`detachFirst` + `destroyNode`
`deleteValue`	heap	`detachValue` + `destroyNode`

> `detach` = remove from list — caller decides memory
>
> `delete` = remove from list AND free — heap only

ONE RULE TO REMEMBER

```
detach  →  structure operation  →  stack and heap
delete  →  memory operation     →  heap only

delete  =  detach  +  destroyNode
```

> If you understand `detach` — `delete` is just two lines.
> If you understand `detachFirst` — `detachValue` is the same loop with one extra case at the head.

THANK

You